

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-25 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-25 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	invisible-gorilla-discussion

Big idea: Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

Overview

Students complete a selective-attention counting task and examine why obvious evidence can be missed.

Student Prompt

Inspect Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Invisible Gorilla Discussion Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Invisible Gorilla Discussion Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	How does attention shape what counts as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how attention is not a neutral spotlight; it decides which evidence enters awareness.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Use a short public-domain-style classroom task, or create your own with students passing a soft object while another visible change occurs.
- Tell students to focus on one countable task so the later miss is meaningful rather than random.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Counting task: students count how many times a blue card is passed while a student in a bright scarf crosses the room.
- Desk task: students count red objects in a photo while a large background detail changes between views.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give students one narrow observation task, such as counting passes or repeated actions.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Run the short stimulus once without interruption.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Ask students to record the target count and anything unusual they noticed.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Reveal the unexpected element and compare what students missed.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how task, expectation, and confidence shaped what became evidence.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- You were not careless; your attention was doing what the task asked it to do.
- What did the task make available as evidence, and what did it make invisible?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use one obvious unexpected feature.
- Challenge: add two unexpected features and ask which one different students notice.

Extension Tasks

- Students design a fairer observation protocol for an eyewitness or scientist.
- Compare selective attention in sport, medicine, driving, and classroom learning.

Related Activities

- Change Blindness Starter
- Eyewitness Trap
- Blind Spot Autobiography